warheads.[80] US officials remained entirely oblivious of the eighty nuclear-capable Meteors on the island.

The Ilyushin-28s were not deemed a significant offensive capability by Washington. Indeed, on the very day that Major Heyser's U-2 was flying over western Cuba, McGeorge Bundy appeared on the TV programme *Issues and Answers* to deny there were nuclear missiles in Cuba. He also said that while Soviet aircraft might represent 'a certain marginal capability for moving against the United States' this was not a cause for concern.[81] With the discovery of the MRBMs the context changed, and in his letter to Nikita Khrushchev on 22 October the President made clear that Soviet 'long-range missile bases and other offensive weapons systems in Cuba' were to be removed.[82] Ironically, none of the Ilyushin-28s that Washington believed nuclear-capable were configured to carry nuclear ordnance. Only six of the nine air force planes Khrushchev had sent in September could carry the Tatyana bomb (and all nine remained in their crates at Holguin airfield).

The existence of Soviet tactical nuclear weapons in Cuba, however, remained unknown in the West until the early 1990s. In *Dr Strangelove*, Soviet Ambassador Alexei de Sadeski (memorably played by Peter Bull) explains the existence of the Doomsday Machine, whose purpose is to deter a US nuclear attack on the Soviet Union. The President's Director of Weapons Research and Development, Dr Strangelove (memorably played by Peter Sellers), is appalled by the fact that the Doomsday Machine has been kept secret: 'but the whole point of the doomsday machine is lost if you keep it a secret. Why didn't you tell the world, eh?'

In Cuba, there were obvious operational reasons not to reveal the whereabouts of the weapons, but the fact that Washington was unaware of their presence risked catastrophe for both sides. It also risked a much greater catastrophe for the Cuban people, though one that Cuban leaders seemed willing to endure. At the Havana conference in 1992, Castro declared:

> Before having the country occupied – totally occupied – we were ready to die in the defense of our country. I would have agreed, in